Prerequisites Install Guide

4 Free Tools for the Full End-to-End Data Analyst Project

This guide walks you through downloading and installing everything you need before starting the IKEA Gifting End to End project video. All four tools are completely free. Work through them in order: once all four are installed, you are ready to jump straight into the project video.

TOOL 1 OF 4

SQL Server 2025 Express

Where we store and clean our data. Free forever, same T-SQL used at most companies.

🔗 **Download:** Search "SQL Server downloads" or go to the official Microsoft SQL Server downloads page. Under the Express edition, click Download Now.

1. Run the downloaded installer.
2. When asked for installation type, choose Basic. This is the simplest option and everything needed for this project is included in it.
3. Accept the license terms and let it install. This takes a few minutes.
4. Once finished, note the instance name shown on the completion screen — usually something like YOURPCNAME\SQLEXPRESS. You will need this in the next step, connecting with SSMS.

TOOL 2 OF 4

SQL Server Management Studio

The application we actually write and run our SQL queries in. A separate download from SQL Server itself.

🔗 **Download:** aka.ms/ssms — this link always points to the current version of SSMS.

1. Run the SSMS installer. It installs on top of Visual Studio Installer components automatically — just let it run.
2. Once installed, open SSMS. You will see a Connect to Server window.
3. In Server Name, type the instance name you noted in the SQL Server install step — for example YOURPCNAME\SQLEXPRESS, or simply localhost\SQLEXPRESS.
4. Leave Authentication as Windows Authentication.
5. Before connecting, click Options, go to the Connection Properties tab, and check Trust Server Certificate. This avoids a certificate error on a fresh local install.
6. Click Connect. You should now see Object Explorer on the left with your SQL Server instance and the default system databases.

> ⚠ **WATCH OUT**
>
> SQL Server and SSMS are Windows-only tools. If you are on a Mac, you have three options: run a Windows virtual machine, use Docker to run SQL Server in a container, or use Azure Data Studio connected to a cloud-hosted SQL database instead.

TOOL 3 OF 4

Anaconda Distribution

Installs Python, Jupyter Notebook, and pandas all in one go. This is where we build the RFM segmentation logic.

🔗 **Download:** anaconda.com/download — choose the Windows or Mac installer depending on your system.

1. Run the installer. Default settings are fine for everything in this project.
2. The install takes a few minutes and needs roughly 3 GB of space — it is a full data science toolkit, not just Python.
3. Once installed, open Anaconda Navigator from your start menu or applications folder.
4. Inside Navigator, find Jupyter Notebook and click Launch. It opens automatically in your browser — that browser tab is your coding environment for the Python part of the project.

> 💡 **KEY POINT**
> If Navigator ever feels slow to open, you can also launch Jupyter directly — open Anaconda Prompt from your start menu and type jupyter notebook, then press Enter.

TOOL 4 OF 4

Power BI Desktop

Free desktop tool — where we build the final three-page dashboard.

🔗 **Download:** Microsoft Store — search "Power BI Desktop" and install. This is the recommended route because it updates automatically. Alternatively, powerbi.microsoft.com/desktop for a direct installer.

1. Install from the Microsoft Store like any other app — click Get, then Install.
2. Open Power BI Desktop once installed.
3. You may be asked to sign in with a Microsoft account — this is optional for building and using reports on your own desktop. You can skip it and continue if you prefer.

YOU'RE READY WHEN...

Go through this final checklist. Once every box is genuinely true, close this guide and head back to the project.

☐ SQL Server Express is installed, and you can see it listed as an instance name (e.g. YOURPCNAME\SQLEXPRESS).

☐ SSMS is installed and you have successfully connected to your SQL Server instance — Object Explorer is visible on the left.

☐ Anaconda is installed and clicking Launch under Jupyter Notebook in Navigator opens a working notebook in your browser.

☐ Power BI Desktop is installed and opens without errors.

☐ Excel or another spreadsheet tool available to export CSV files.